Adaptation

By Elaine May

ANNOUNCER'S VOICE: **(Pg 5)** Good evening, ladies and gentlemen. You are about to watch a new version of an old game that all of you have played, and some of you may recognize--ADAPTATION - an exciting contest in which anyone can win simply by figuring out the rules and overcoming the odds. Watch closely, as tonight's first contestant, Phil Benson, attempts to win the Adaptation Prize by reaching the Security Square concealed somewhere on our gameboard. [Now let's play . . .] ADAPTATION!!!!!!!

INTRODUCTION

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GAMES MASTER: **(Pg 6)** You are born. Move three spaces forward. You are now the son of, liberal, middle-income, Protestant, white, parents.

MOTHER: Harry, It's a boy. I'm going to name him Phil.

GAMES MASTER: **(Pg 7-8)** You are [now] five [years] old. Score one Point for Maturity and advance to your nearest Health Through Information square.

PHIL: Mommy, how does the baby get into the mommy's stomach?

MOTHER: Via sexual relations between man and woman, Phil. *(Buzzer sounds. When it stops, Phil has become a year older.)*

PHIL: Mama, what's sex?

MOTHER: Sex is a term that defines the . . . *(Buzzer sounds again. When it stops, Phil has become another year older.)*

PHIL: Mom, what's a Negro?

MOTHER: Phil, do you know how when you see a flower sometimes there's a white flower

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and sometimes there's a dark flower. Bees go to both of them because bees like dark flowers as much as they like white. And that's why when we say the word Negro we must think of it as something very, very beautiful. And we must try not to use the word outside the context of a sentence that has to do with social justice.

GAMES MASTER: You have learned to Dissemble. Score two Points for Maturity and advance to Public School. *(Phil looks around in awe at the new larger world he is inhabiting when an announcement comes over the intercom from the PRINCIPAL)*

PRINCIPAL: Any student using the elevator without an official pass from the dean will be graded down ten points in Living With Others. Remember, you are only second graders but any bad mark you receive on your school record now may keep you from getting into the college of your choice.

PHIL: *(Phil walks down the hall, aging in mannerisms as he does so – he notices a line on the ground, which he hesitates to cross – He stops, unsure of himself)*

GAMES MASTER: **(Pg 9-10)** And now--take a giant step into Prepubescence.

PHIL: *(Phil lurches forward as if pushed from behind; once on the other side of the line, he flexes his muscles, pops a couple of pimples on his face and feels his chin for growing facial hair.)*

GAMES MASTER: Your mother is called to school for a conference with the school principal. Go to your nearest Isolation Square. *(Phil turns to stand in the corner)*

MOTHER: What did he do, Mr. Ashley?

ASHLEY: He wrote something on the walls about one of the students - who happens to be colored. *(Reading from a slip of paper.)* "Jim is a dark flower." We're trying to appease his mother now, but she's threatened to release the story to the New York Post ... which would destroy the image we have tried to build up for this school as sub-standard but equal. Frankly, Mrs. Benson, it's a dilemma.

GAMES MASTER: You are sent to a progressive, private [high] school. Advance three squares to Social Inflation.

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PHIL: **(Pg 11-12)** *(Phil makes an abrupt right turn and speaks with some friends)* What are you choosing as an extra-curricular activity, Mark?

MARK: I'm joining the Drama Society. (in an overly dramatic voice) If I learn to speak with feeling it will help me get girls.

PHIL: What are you choosing, Irving?

IRVING: I've decided to become a safety patrol boy. There's been too much bloodshed. Too many good kids gone. I [want] to make the corners of this city a place where kids can cross without fear.

PHIL: *(Phil speaks to the audience)* A safety patrol . . . Have I changed myself enough to change the world? Do I have the right to stop traffic? *(Suddenly ... he jumps to save a wayward child and says in a deep voice.)* Watch it there! You're safe now, kid. *(Phil assumes the role of the child and in a childlike voice says)* Thank you, Safety Patrol Boy. *(In his normal voice, to the audience)* Do I dare?

GAMES MASTER: **(Pg 16-18)** Start to think about your college and advance to your nearest Probable Long Term Goals Square.

PHIL: It's between Berkeley . . .

GAMES MASTER: *(Hands Phil a letter, shaking his head)* You have been rejected by Berkeley.

PHIL: or Yale . . .

GAMES MASTER: *(Hands Phil a letter, shaking his head)* You have been rejected by Yale. Retreat to the nearest Panic Square.

PHIL: *(In a panic, he desperately tries to think of another option . . .)* I think I'll try the University of Miami?

GAMES MASTER: *(Smiling broadly)* You are accepted by the University of Miami. Advance to your nearest Commitment Square and begin to examine your potential.

PHIL: I'm not sure what to major in, I'm torn between Hotel Management and [Drama]. But I've always had a dream that someday I'd make it . . . in hotel management like

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some of the great ones. Hilton, Sheraton . . . [Trump]. *(Phil takes his place in his first college class, prepared to take notes)*

PROFESSOR: Good morning, gentlemen. My name is Professor Olsen, o-l-s-e-n, and I will be teaching the first semester of Hotel Management 101 - Organization, Administration and Management. Or as we in the field have come to call it, O.A.M. O! A! M!

PHIL: *(chanting)* O! A! M! O! A! M!

GAMES MASTER: (Pg 22-24) You have made an "A" in O.A.M. Advance to Find the Right Girl.

PHIL: *(Takes a step to the left and speaks to Doris)* I love you. Do you love me?

DORIS: I want to know where I stand, Phil. You know what I mean.

PHIL: Listen, Doris, if I thought marriage would solve it . . . I mean, I know that I enjoy being with you and if I were going to make the move you'd be the first one I'd call. I hope someday to love and have a home. But right now. . . . I don't know.

DORIS: Then I'm leaving. I'm sorry, Phil.

PHIL: You're leaving me? Don't tell me you're sorry. Just tell me where I stand.

DORIS: Listen, if I thought marriage would solve it . . .

PHIL. *(Dropping to one knee to propose)* It will. It will.

GAMES MASTER: You are Engaged.

PHIL: Oh, my God.

GAMES MASTER: **(Pg 25)** You go into debt and become a Homeowner. Take a Credit Card and advance towards Upward Mobility.

PHIL: **(Pg 24)** Oh, my God.

GAMES MASTER: **(Pg 26)** You are transferred to a larger city and have your first child. Advance to Fatherhood.

PHIL: **(Pg 24)** Oh, my God.

GAMES MASTER: **(Pg 27)** *(Buzzer.)* Advance to Middle Age.

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PHIL: Wait a minute!

GAMES MASTER: The world is getting faster. Take out an Insurance Policy and advance to Political Involvement.

PHIL: Doris! Doris! The Chicago Hilton is going to be used by the Democrats for the National Democratic Convention-and guess who's going to be in charge. Yours truly. I can't wait. Caucuses, smoke-filled rooms, favorite sons ... Doris, this is the moment I've been preparing for all my life. This is what it's all about. This is O.A.M. [But it's all moving so fast!]

GAMES MASTER: You have reached a Long-Term Goal. Advance to Emotional Fulfillment and take another step toward Success.

AFTER DINNER SPEAKER: **(Pg 29-30)** And so, to Phil Benson, the Hilton Hotel Chain awards this solid gold engraved master key that fits the utility closet of any Hilton hotel on the Eastern Seaboard.

GAMES MASTER: You have retired with moderate wealth. Take two steps sideways toward Security and . . . . have a Coronary.

PHIL: *(Has a heart attack and speaks with difficulty)* I had so many dreams I wanted to earn a Super Bonus Card and have a house in the country And I wanted to be on intimate terms with a congressman or a movie star so that my father would be proud of me and my mother would think I was somebody. If I could have played a little longer, I know I could have found the Security Square . . . Where did I go wrong? *(Phil dies)*

GAMES MASTER: You have spoken your last words. Remain where you are and die.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2005 National Qualifier
2006 National Qualifier
2009 National Qualifier
2012 National Qualifier
PA State Champ
Ohio State Qualifier

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